

parts of the continent. But they were also colonists and traders with a sophisticated artistic culture who left a lasting imprint on the places they invaded and settled.

An unstoppable force

Within six years of the Lindisfarne raid, bands of Vikings—or “Danes” as they were known in Anglo-Saxon England—were targeting the wealth of other Christian sites in England, Scotland, Ireland, and France. Key to the success of these missions was the Viking longship, a slender vessel with a shallow bottom that enabled its crew to sail far up waterways and alight stealthily on shores. Each ship could carry up to 80 warriors, recruited by a warlord whose authority depended on his military prowess and his success in capturing booty for his followers.

No single motive drove the Vikings to venture across the sea. In parts of Scandinavia, population growth may have forced young men into a piratical lifestyle; in others, perhaps the increasing strength of local clan leaders sparked power struggles that pushed the losers into exile. And the newly rich trading towns in northern Europe were irresistible targets for a warrior society in which a reputation for valiant deeds was a great asset.

Conquest and settlement

As the Vikings' raiding parties grew in size, many of the men started to settle in the territories they invaded, including those in Britain and France. In the late 9th century, England was divided into a number of kingdoms that offered no coherent resistance to the Viking challenge, while France was consumed by civil war.

This disunited opposition helped the Vikings to conquer northern and central England—where they established a kingdom that lasted almost 100 years—and to occupy land in northern France, where their descendants became French-speaking Normans. In the east, Vikings traded and raided along Russia's rivers, which brought them silver from the Islamic world and contact with the Byzantine Empire.

By the 11th century, most of the Scandinavian kingdoms had adopted Christianity, and turned from raiding and pillaging to more organized settlement and conquest. Cnut of Denmark created a Viking North Sea empire that included Denmark, Norway, and England. Yet it did not survive his death, and in 1066, an unsuccessful attempt to claim the English throne by the Norwegian King Harald Hardrada, was the final flourish of the Viking age that began with the sack of Lindisfarne. ■

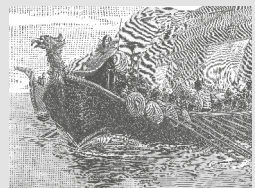
Viking expansion in the North Atlantic

The Vikings used their knowledge of winds and currents to navigate the seas and discover new lands. Around 800, they colonized the Faroe Islands, and used them as a stepping stone to explore the North Atlantic. By the 870s, their ships had reached Iceland, where settlers founded a colony that grew politically independent.

In 982, Erik the Red, exiled from Iceland for murder, stumbled upon Greenland and established a new colony there. A Norse saga tells how, 18 years later, Erik's son, Leif Erikson, was driven off course at sea and landed in a region teeming with hardwood forests and wild grapes that he called Vinland (Land of Wine).

Subsequent expeditions to this area, which is located in what is now Newfoundland in eastern Canada, led to a tiny Viking colony, but this was abandoned after

attacks by hostile indigenous people. Nevertheless, Leif and his crew had been the first Europeans to set foot on North American soil.



The Vikings were among the most skilled shipbuilders, sailors, and navigators in the Western world of the early Middle Ages.